> Is it the hairs that are Nāgasena, Master? Is it the nails or the teeth or the flesh or the bones? Is it the name? Is it the sensations, the perceptions, the consciousness? Is it none of these things?

The sage replies that “Nāgasena” is effectively none of these things, and the king seems to have won the discussion: if Nāgasena is none of these, then he must be something else—and this something else will be the person Nāgasena who therefore exists.

But the sage turns his own argument against him, asking what a chariot consists of:

> Are the wheels the chariot? Is the axle? Is the chassis the chariot? Is the chariot the sum of its parts?

The king replies cautiously that certainly “chariot” refers only to the relationship among the ensemble of wheels, axle, and chassis, to their working together and in relation to us—and that there does not exist an entity “chariot” beyond these relations and events. Nāgasena triumphs: in the same way as “chariot,” the name “Nāgasena” designates nothing more than a collection of relations and events.

We are processes, events, composite and limited in space and time. But if we are not an individual entity, what is it that founds our identity and its unity? What makes it so—that I am Carlo—and that my hair and my nails and my feet are considered part of me, as well as my anger and my dreams, and that I consider myself to be the same Carlo as yesterday, the same as tomorrow; the one who thinks, suffers, and perceives?

There are different ingredients that combine to produce our identity. Three of these are important for the argument of this book:

1.

The first is that every one of us identifies with a *point of view* in the world. The world is reflected in each one of us through a rich spectrum of correlations essential for our survival.[107] Each of us is a complex process that reflects the world and elaborates the information we receive in a way that is strictly integrated.[108]

2.

The second ingredient on which our identity is based is the same as for the chariot. In the process of reflecting the world, we organize it into entities: we conceive of the world by grouping and segmenting it as best we can in a